

Its use by the Boers was a very important factor in the defeat of the British forces because it was impossible for the British to locate the Boers' weapons. Around the same time, in the Spanish-American War (1898), some of the US troops were still using mainly gunpowder-driven single-shot rifles and struggled against the Spanish, who were armed with magazine-loading rifles and smokeless-powder cartridges. While hidden from view, the Spanish were able to target the US soldiers easily, without giving away their own positions.

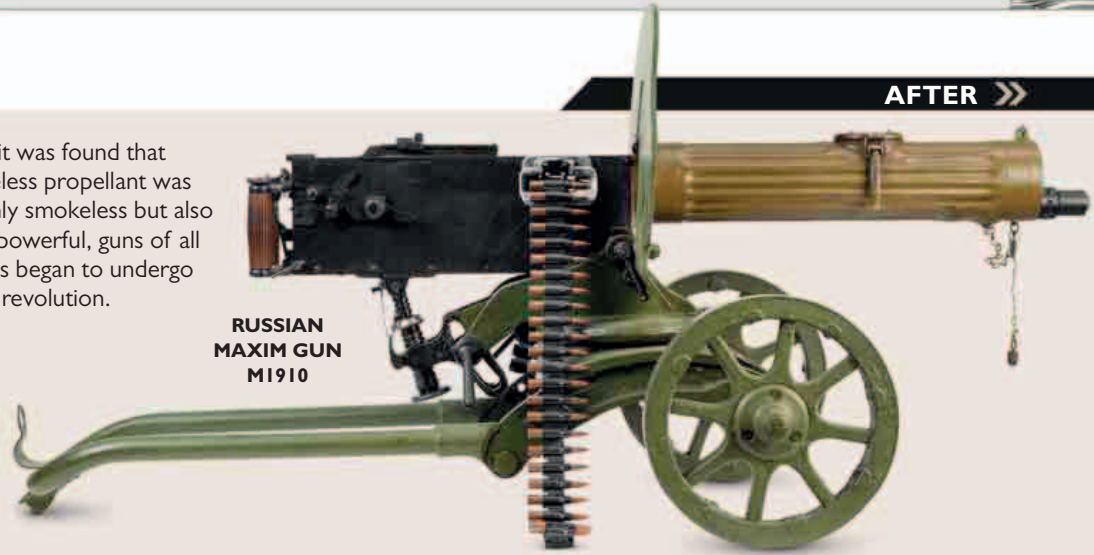
Smokeless powder prompted the development of guns large and small with power undreamed of a decade earlier. Long-range rifles and machine-guns became a reality and would change the face of warfare in the decades to come.

▼ WINNING SAN JUAN HILL

In the Battle of San Juan Hill in the Spanish-American War (1898), American soldiers (in the foreground) suffered heavy casualties under fire from Spanish forces, who stayed hidden with their use of smokeless powder. Tactical errors, however, eventually forced the Spanish to retreat.

Once it was found that smokeless propellant was not only smokeless but also more powerful, guns of all natures began to undergo a new revolution.

RUSSIAN
MAXIM GUN
M1910



• **RIFLES WITH FAR GREATER POWER** evolved, firing new bullets that traveled much faster, with ranges of 1 mile (1.6km) or more and the ability to inflict much more damage.

• **LONG-RANGE BATTLES** could be fought, and even though visibility was improved in the absence of thick smoke, enemies became more difficult to spot and concealment became more important.

• **A NEW BREED OF FIREARMS** evolved, made possible by smokeless powder. These included the first fully automatic weapon—the Maxim gun.

• **THE INCREASE IN FIREPOWER** combined with simplicity in function and manufacture began the age of modern firearms and artillery, which continues today.

